

SPY VERSUS SPY

A new chief for the crisis-ridden Research and Analysis Wing reignites the debate over the role of officers on deputation as against its permanent cadre

| By Sandeep Unnithan |

From his office in the swank 11-storey but unmarked white building atop the Research and Analysis Wing (R&AW) headquarters, secretary (research), as the chief of India's external intelligence agency is called, can see an ominous sight—a Hindu crematorium and a Muslim cemetery. The joke goes that the agency's founder, legendary spymaster Rameshwar Nath Kao, did not care much for *vaastu* when he commissioned the building in Delhi's CGO complex over three decades ago. Others take it as a prophecy for the 40-year-old spy agency, already in the throes of a severe mid-life crisis.

K.C. Verma, who took over as R&AW chief this month, has much at hand than merely repositioning his office. On the first day of his new assignment, a R&AW official was arrested by CBI for allegedly accepting bribes. The more serious concern, however, is the withering away of the Research Analysis Service (RAS), the permanent cadre which forms R&AW's backbone. It has around 200 Class-I officers and needs at least eight officers each year to fill up vacancies. In the last eight years, RAS has managed to attract just six new recruits and its future seems uncertain.

Set up to collect external intelligence, especially in the neighbourhood and provide strategic analysis to help shape government policy, R&AW's reputation has been shrinking in inverse proportion to India's rise on the global stage and the myriad security threats posed by its rival agency, the ISI. The tenure of R&AW's previous chief, Ashok

Chaturvedi, arguably the most controversial ever, was marked by infighting, allegations of nepotism and even a case of attempted suicide outside the PMO by a senior R&AW official who alleged harassment. "In investigation, R&AW is the B-team to the IB and in foreign policy inputs, they are the B-team to the IPS," says a senior Intelligence Bureau official.

Insiders see the appointment of Verma, handpicked by Home Minister P. Chidambaram, as yet another demoralising sign of the bleak career prospects for the RAS cadre. Verma, a 1971 batch IPS officer, is seen as an outsider who has spent nearly three decades in the IB. He was appointed over the three senior-most officials in the agency—P. Vijay Kumar, Rana Banerjee and Sanjeev Tripathi—all from the first batch of Class-I RAS officers recruited in 1971.

Though this was not unprecedented, the Government has routinely appointed outsiders to head the

organisation and bring in needed deep-rooted changes. IB hand A.S. Dulat was brought in nearly a decade ago and IPS officer P.K. Hormese Tharakan four years ago to head the organisation in the wake of the Rabinder Singh spy scandal.

Neither has been able to address the primary concern of cadre management that bedevils the organisation. A serious attempt was made during Tharakan's tenure when a committee headed by Vice-Admiral S.C.S. Bangara, former commandant of the National Defence Academy, presented 42 recommendations to completely overhaul R&AW's training and selection process. Among the suggestions was a selection process similar to the Services Selection Board (SSB) which selects candidates for the armed forces, improving training standards which had been diluted over time and in-house training to produce a cadre specialised in collecting foreign intelligence. The report also recommended periodic mid-career courses to upgrade the skills of its officers. "If they set the cadre right and the training is improved, you will have a dynamic force," says Vice-Admiral Bangara.

It is unclear whether any of these recommendations, submitted a month before Tharakan handed charge to Chaturvedi, were ever implemented. "As long as the avenue of deputations works, the Government is not worried," says Major-General Vinay Kumar Singh (retired), a former R&AW official.

The IB has little infighting because all its officials are either IPS officers or are directly recruited. But the sheer multitude of government services within R&AW ensure friction and battles over seniority. Officials

THE NEW R&AW CHIEF IS AN IPS OFFICER

FROM THE 1971 BATCH OF IPS OFFICERS, VERMA TOOK OVER AS R&AW CHIEF ON FEBRUARY 23, 2009. HE WAS APPOINTED OVER THE THREE SENIOR-MOST OFFICIALS IN THE AGENCY—P. VIJAY KUMAR, RANA BANERJEE AND SANJEEV TRIPATHI—ALL FROM THE FIRST BATCH OF CLASS-I RAS OFFICERS RECRUITED IN 1971.



K.C. VERMA



VIKRAM SOOD, FORMER R&AW CHIEF

Deputationists gain expertise and leave, which is a big loss to RAW. It should strengthen its permanent cadre.